NORTH DAKOTA

The Peace Garden State



The wind on the Northern Plains does not negotiate. It sweeps down from Canada across the open prairie of North Dakota with nothing to slow it—no mountains, no forests, just mile after flat mile of grassland and sky. The settlers who arrived in the late 1800s understood quickly that surviving a Dakota winter required more than determination. It required food that was warm to the bone, filling enough to sustain a body through hours of brutal outdoor labor, and simple enough to make with whatever the root cellar and the flour sack had to offer.

The Germans from Russia brought exactly that kind of food with them.

This particular group carried a layered history unlike almost any other immigrant population in America. Catherine the Great had invited German farmers to settle the Volga River region of Russia in the 1760s, promising them fertile land, religious freedom, and exemption from military service. For roughly a century, these communities thrived on the Russian steppe, maintaining their German language, their Lutheran and Catholic faith, and their culinary traditions while absorbing the hearty, peasant-practical cooking sensibility of the Russian countryside around them. When those promises were broken in the 1870s and military conscription loomed, they left—and many of them followed land agents and railroad pamphlets straight to the Dakota Territory.

They arrived in the Red River Valley and the James River lowlands in significant numbers through the 1880s and 1890s, settling towns like Emmons County, Logan County, and the rolling farmland surrounding Wishek and Linton. They broke sod, built churches, and—critically—they cooked. Knoephla soup came with them, a dish born of German thrift and Russian winter wisdom, built from the simplest ingredients a farming family could reliably have on hand: flour, eggs, potatoes, broth, cream, and onion. The dumplings—Knӧpfle in the old German dialect, meaning roughly "little buttons"—were pinched or cut by hand and dropped into simmering broth, where they swelled into soft, pillowy rounds that turned a thin soup into something sustaining enough to carry a farmer through an afternoon of frozen fieldwork.

In the farmhouse kitchens of central North Dakota, knoephla was not a special occasion dish. It was Tuesday. It was the meal that appeared when the temperature dropped and the snow came sideways and nobody was going anywhere. Grandmothers made it from memory, never from a recipe, adjusting the dough by feel and the broth by taste. It was passed hand to hand across generations not through cookbooks but through standing beside someone in a kitchen and watching until you knew it in your own hands.

Today, knoephla soup remains one of the most beloved and deeply rooted dishes in North Dakota—served in church basements, small-town diners, and family kitchens from Bismarck to the Canadian border. When you make this soup, you are reaching back across more than a century of migration, resilience, and prairie survival. The dumplings are forgiving, the broth is deeply comforting, and the first warm bowl on a cold day will make you understand immediately why these settlers held onto this recipe through two countries, an ocean, and a continent. Make a full pot. It only gets better the next day.

KNOEPHLA SOUP

Pillowy dumplings, tender potatoes, and a rich, creamy broth come together in a bowl that tastes exactly like someone's grandmother loves you.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

SOUP

- 4 Tbsp butter
- 1 small onion, diced
- 2 carrots, diced
- 2 celery stalks, diced
- 4 cups chicken broth
- 2 cups diced potatoes, Yukon Gold preferred
- 1 cup heavy cream
- Salt and pepper, to taste

DUMPLINGS

- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 egg
- ¼ cup milk

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Sauté the Vegetables*: In a large pot, melt butter over medium heat. Add onions, carrots, and celery, cooking until soft (5 minutes).
2. *Simmer the Soup*: Pour in chicken broth and bring to a boil. Add diced potatoes and simmer for 10–12 minutes, until potatoes are tender.
3. *Make the Knoephla Dough*: In a bowl, mix flour and salt. Add egg and milk, stirring until a soft dough forms.
4. *Shape the Knoephla*: On a floured surface, roll the dough into thin ropes and cut into small bite-sized pieces.
5. *Cook the Dumplings*: Drop the dumplings into the simmering soup and cook for 5–7 minutes, until they float and are cooked through.
6. *Finish with Cream*: Stir in heavy cream, salt, and pepper. Simmer for another 5 minutes, then serve hot.

